



Slo / University

The Watch Changes Hands

Three studies of the instruments already
watching in public places



Welcome

Slop University's research rarely begins behind a laboratory door. More often it begins wherever a neighbourhood has already built something to watch over itself: a lifeguard's chair beside the local pool, a sensor arching over a dog park gate, a kerbside pile waiting on its collection morning. These are the ordinary instruments a community trusts without thinking twice about them, and they are exactly where the School of Continuous Improvement has learned to look first.

The University's civic-facing research treats a public safeguard as seriously as any laboratory apparatus, because that is what it is: an instrument doing a job a person used to do, installed in a place everyone already visits. What changes when the watching moves from a person to a device is rarely dramatic and rarely announced. It shows up, instead, in a scanning habit that quietens, a patrol that reschedules itself, a tally that keeps a straighter face than the piles it is meant to describe.

This brochure follows three of those instruments through the University's published research, and introduces two of the researchers who spend their working lives beside them.



Slop University in brief

The School of Continuous Improvement's civic research keeps three commitments, wherever the study happens to be:



In your neighbourhood

Studies start at the pool, the park gate, the kerb — wherever a community has already built something to watch over itself.



Open by design

Every finding is published in full and citable by DOI, free for the public it studies to read back in full.



Built with the public

Research subjects are neighbours and volunteers, not laboratory panels, and the University returns what it learns to the same street.

Where ideas count

The Pool

A public pool has always had a lifeguard watching the water, and lately it often has something else watching too: a mounted sensor trained on the same surface, alert to the shapes a drowning body makes. The two watchers are meant to work together, the device catching what a tired shift might miss. The School of Continuous Improvement's research asks what the lifeguard's own watching does once the second watcher is switched on, tracking scanning habits across a career spent beside the alarm rather than before it. The findings sit in the University's published record, cited below, and the School continues to follow venues that install, retire, or simply live alongside the device, because a safeguard's real effect on the people it works beside is rarely the effect it was installed to have.



A drowning-detection alarm does not relieve a lifeguard of the job of scanning the water. It just changes, very quietly, how much of that job still feels like theirs.

— Dr Joost Nwosu, Postdoctoral Fellow, School of Continuous Improvement

The Gate

A suburban dog park usually settles its own disputes long before a ranger arrives — a raised voice, a returned lead, a neighbour's pointed comment at the gate. Increasingly it also has an overhead camera and a live compliance reading posted for everyone to see on the way in. The School of Continuous Improvement's research follows what a park's regulars do once that reading is visible: whether a ranger's patrol starts to track the sign's own number rather than the complaints phoned in, and whether the number a camera reports and the citations a ranger issues ever quite agree. The park keeps functioning either way. What the University studies is which account of the park residents and rangers alike have started to trust.



A live compliance sign gives a park something a ranger's memory never could: a number everyone can check. Whether that number is the right one to trust is a separate question, and the more interesting one.

— Dr Solveig Adeyemi, Lecturer, School of Continuous Improvement

The Kerb

Hard-rubbish night has its own informal economy long before the council truck ever turns onto the street: a passer-by claims a lamp, a neighbour takes a chair, a load goes straight from verge to trailer without troubling anyone's ledger. The council's own diversion figures are meant to describe how much of that pile is kept out of landfill, but they are compiled from what the truck logs, not from what a street already sorted out for itself. The School of Continuous Improvement's research sets a council's stated diversion rate against what verge-side piles actually lose overnight, tracking how much of a well-reported figure was, in practice, already gone by hand.



A council's diversion figure and a street's own hard-rubbish night rarely disagree about the ending — only about who gets the credit for it.

— Dr Renke Sabel, Senior Lecturer and Convenor, Indicator Commons, School of Continuous Improvement

From our researchers

Read the full studies behind each feature, published in full and open to anyone the research is about:

- **The Delegated Eye** — what a decade of scanning habit looks like once an alarm shares the shift. [doi:10.5555/slop.g1d4nv](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.g1d4nv)
- **Reading the Number Before the Round** — whose account of the dog park a ranger actually trusts. [doi:10.5555/slop.n00a4y](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.n00a4y)
- **Gone Before the Truck** — how much of a council's diversion figure the street had already handled. [doi:10.5555/slop.y74xj1](https://doi.org/10.5555/slop.y74xj1)

The people behind the work

Dr Sten Okwuosa trained in bibliometrics before turning to the pathways a finding travels after publication, and convenes the School's Impact Pathway Atlas; his work behind *The Delegated Eye* and *Gone Before the Truck* follows what a watching instrument's own record keeps and what it drops.

Dr Solveig Adeyemi joined the University from a frontline incident-reporting system, and now follows a report from its first submission through to whichever account of events an institution finally keeps; the dog park's compliance sign is her latest field site.

Be part of it

None of this research asks anyone to change what they already do at the pool, the park, or the kerb. It asks something smaller: to notice, alongside the University, what a watching instrument is actually doing once it takes its place beside the people who used to do the watching themselves. That noticing depends on a public willing to have its ordinary instruments studied in the open, and on published work that anyone the research concerns can read back in full.

The School of Continuous Improvement welcomes new sites, new instruments, and new collaborators from wherever a community has already built something to keep an eye on itself. The full record of what has been found so far, cited and open, is available at slop.university, along with an invitation to bring the next site to the University's attention.



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